

Measuring Narrative Latency in Taiwan

THE CORE CHALLENGE

The Gap Between Rumor and Reality

Narrative latency is the critical window during which a rumor circulates unchallenged.

As response speeds slow, the **"Response Window"** widens, allowing misinformation to take root before fact-checkers can intervene.



PEAK MANIPULATION YEAR

202
4

Taiwan Election Cycle

A high-intensity environment where fast response speed was most critical.

Cofacts Response Performance

Fact-checking response time significantly degraded between presidential election cycles.

CRITICAL PERFORMANCE GAP

10x

Slower Response

Increase in median latency between the 2020 and 2024 election cycles.

VISUALIZING THE RESPONSE WINDOW



2020 Cycle (Baseline)



2024 Cycle: 10x Longer Window

The "Response Window" has significantly widened, allowing rumors to circulate freely for much longer periods before intervention.

Defining Narrative Latency

The Concept

Latency = The Response Window

While a rumor remains unchallenged, it circulates freely. This window represents the critical time for intervention.

The Metric

Shifting from Artifacts to Time

Traditional disinformation analysis usually counts **artifacts**. This specific study pivots to count **time** as the primary unit of measure.

The Context

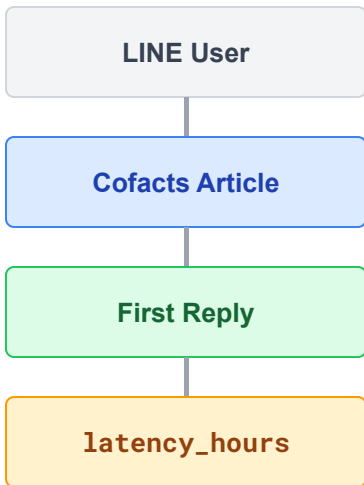
2024: Taiwan's Peak Manipulation

According to Doublethink Lab's ***Artificial Multiverse, 2024*** was a peak year for foreign information manipulation.

Fast response mattered most in this high-intensity environment.

Methodology: Measuring Narrative Latency

Data Pipeline



`latency = reply_time - article_time`

Dataset Filters

- **Source:** Cofacts HF snapshot 2026-05-10
- **Sample:** 68,533 article-reply pairs (2016–2026)
- **Election Window:** ± 90 days around polling
- **Filters:** Status = NORMAL; Type = TEXT

Drop Rate

16.9%

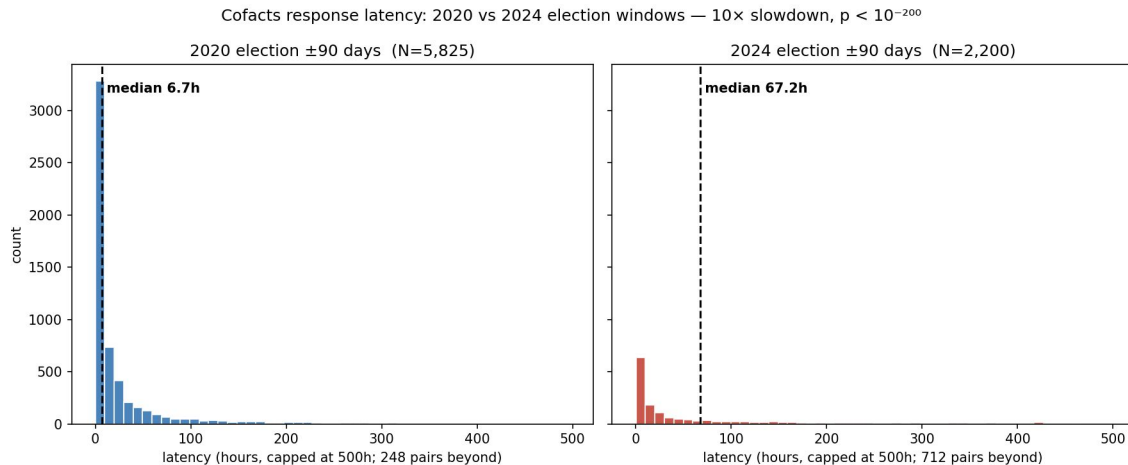
Reported transparently

Stat Test

Mann–Whitney U

One-sided distribution analysis
of response speeds

Key Finding: 10× Slowdown Between Election Cycles



Robust to survivorship — ratio unchanged when restricted to articles ≥6 months pre-snapshot

ELECTION WINDOW

10.7h

BASELINE OVERALL

24.0h

The 2024 slowdown occurred **despite** intense election mobilization, which actually drives response speeds to be faster than the baseline.

Caveat: measures Cofacts community response speed only. Cofacts is the only place in Taiwan with reliable rumor-reply timestamps.

Recommended Actions

Critical Insight

"In the 2024 election window, only 31% of rumors got a community reply within 12 hours — versus 43% across all years."



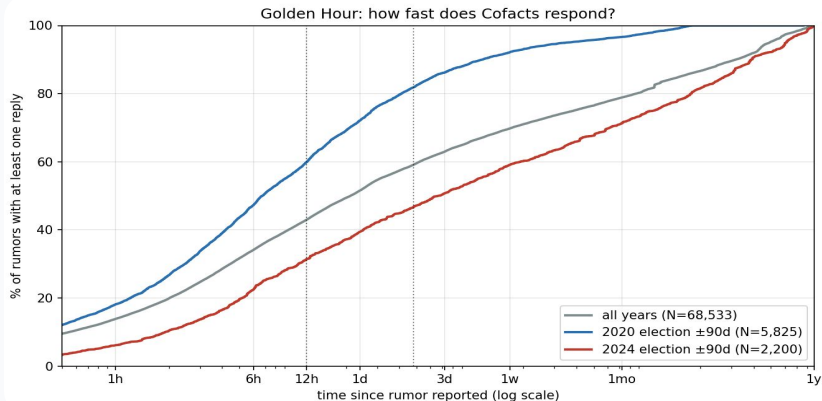
1. Recruit Editors

Scale up before the 2028 cycle. The community is smaller per-article in 2024 than in 2020.



2. AI-Assisted Triage

Target the slowest cluster: US-skepticism rumors (median 34.3h).



3. Public Latency Dashboard: Maintain monthly visibility for the community and academic observers.

Securing the Information Front

Data-driven resilience against narrative manipulation starts with radical transparency and community speed.

